There are nineteen Lok Sabha seats in the Hindi heartland where over 30 per cent of voters happen to be Muslim. For our purposes here, let's call them Muslim-significant seats. Of these, the BJP won only five seats (19.6 per cent of the votes) in 2009, fourteen (41.6 per cent) in 2014 and seven (39.6 per cent) in 2019. This would imply that its support base in these Muslim-significant seats declined in 2019. However, when we look at vote shares, it is clear that the party grew much deeper roots in these seats during the past decade. In 2009, BJP won only one of the nineteen Muslim-significant seats with more than 40 per cent vote share, which, as we have seen before, is a performance benchmark that indicates a decisive presence.[9] That number went up to nine in 2014 and to thirteen in 2019. In other words, the BJP in 2019 won more than 40 per cent of the vote in 68.4 per cent of Muslim-dominated seats in the Hindi heartland (see Figure 5.1). In sharp contrast, the Congress, which had won the largest number of these Muslim seats in 2009 (six seats, 16.4 per cent vote share), got reduced to a rump by 2019 (one seat, 11 per cent vote share).

Figure 5.1: The BJP Expanded Its Base in Muslim-significant Seats, While the Congress Shrunk in the Hindi Heartland (Lok Sabha: 2009–2019)